Describe one example of artificial intelligence and evaluate its impact on society.

Recognizing differences between human and artificial intelligence (AI) is becoming more difficult (Jeanneau et al., 2023, para. 1), and this creates a need for technology that distinguishes humans from AI. One example of this is a device called Orb that uses iris recognition technology. According to the company that made the Orb, 18 million people had been verified through this so far and had used their verification 450 million times (Hays, 2026, para. 27). However, there are privacy concerns and risks of misuse, and various movements have emerged to address these issues (Wainaina et al., 2025, pp. 367-368; Siad & Sagar, 2025, pp. 395-396). This essay describes the Orb's process and technologies and evaluates its impacts on society in terms of nations and companies. The essay also argues that human verification technologies such as the Orb are necessary for society. Therefore, to maximize their benefits, the risks must be mitigated by national regulations and companies' efforts.

The Orb is an iris recognition device created by the company Tools for Humanity. The company believes that this device can identify humans while preserving privacy (Tidy, 2023, para. 6). The first step in the verification is to stare into the Orb for an iris scan. After the scanning, the device will prove uniqueness based on a large database (Tidy, 2023, para. 16-18). If humanness is proven, cryptocurrency is given to the user in exchange (Tidy, 2023, para. 18). Tools for Humanity published an online version of the Orb as an app, so this process can also be operated digitally. Moreover, Jeanneau et al. (2023, para. 28) emphasize the roles of computer vision and deep learning technologies in iris recognition. Computer vision detects objects in visual data (Lipizzi, 2024, p. 81) and enables the segmentation of pupil, iris, and eyeball in iris images (Jeanneau et al., 2023, para. 12). In addition, deep learning autonomously learns patterns using neural networks to understand those images in diverse ways (Jeanneau et al., 2023, para. 11). Recently, deep learning has enhanced computer vision, resulting in more sophisticated iris recognition (Jeanneau et al., 2023, para. 11).

In contrast to the company's goal of verifying humans without privacy problems, there are ethical issues that lead to regulations at the national level. The nations are mainly concerned with the biometric data that is collected. The Orb verifies humanness through iris because it is the most unique part of a person, even more than the fingerprints (Hays, 2026,

para. 25). This decision, however, paradoxically demonstrates sensitivity of the data. Although the company argues that it is only used to create uniqueness (Sweet & Musambi, 2023, para. 16) and no data is stored (Tidy, 2023, para. 25), some privacy experts caution against the malicious use (Tidy, 2023, para. 25). Thus, the nations also could not ignore privacy concerns and the potential misuse (Wainaina et al., 2025, pp. 367-368; Siad & Sagar, 2025, pp. 395-396). For instance, Germany, Nigeria, and Portugal suspended new access to the Orb (Reuters, 2024, as cited in Siad & Sagar, 2025, p. 395), and the European Union's General Data Protection Regulation has required the company to delete iris scans (Siad & Sagar, 2025, p. 396). Meanwhile, there are different concerns in developing countries with limited regulations. For example, Wainaina et al. (2025, pp. 370-371) argue that some regulations in Kenya, such as the Data Protection Act (2019), Computer Misuse and Cybercrimes Act (2018), and Consumer Protection Act (2012), still have loopholes in protecting the biodata and ensuring consent of users. These regulatory gaps could be dangerous opportunities for foreign companies to test their operations and to extract vulnerable populations' data (Siad & Sagar, 2025, p. 393). Specifically, Wainaina et al. (2025, p. 369) suggest that Kenya might be a testing ground for the data extraction, and Siad and Sagar (2025, p. 391) claim that the company's broad activities in Kenya were possible due to Kenya's weak regulations. Tools for Humanity, however, is changing its strategy in the US to be more cautious in consideration of American protective regulations (Tidy, 2023, para. 12). These examples demonstrate that the strong regulations to protect citizens influence the company's activities. Moreover, the national responses show that the ethical issues are significant and must be addressed by the governments. Also, governments should establish clear rules by defining the concepts of consent and data specifically to be more protective.

Despite these negative responses from the countries, several companies have introduced the Orb's verification system. For instance, Tinder formed a partnership with the company to offer an additional way that people can be verified (Hays, 2026, para. 17), and Zoom, which also formed a partnership, plans to provide a 'proof of humanity' badge that can be attached to a profile after the verification (Hays, 2026, para. 2). In addition, an Okta executive stated that the explosion of AI creates fundamentally different problems, and Okta announced the use of Tools for Humanity's verification system (World, 2026, para. 1-2). These adoptions of Tinder, Zoom, and Okta could result from the concerns about digital crimes. According to the Federal Trade Commission, the US lost more than one billion

dollars in 2025 because of romance scams (FTC, as cited in Hays, 2026, para. 16), and the research from Deloitte estimates that the US loss could reach 40 billion dollars by 2027 due to deepfake scams (Deloitte, as cited in Hays, 2026, para. 21). These constant losses compel the companies to develop countermeasures. Furthermore, Adler et al. (2025, pp. 9-12) argue that existing countermeasures, such as CAPTCHA and appearance-based verification, including video calls and selfie checks, are not robust to advanced AI. This study indicates that companies need to adopt a new approach to preventing digital crime. Therefore, the new adoption of the Orb's verification system by companies, such as Tinder, Zoom, and Okta, could be interpreted as the prevention of the future loss and the early mitigation of weak verifications. These findings show that some companies regard the Orb as a potential countermeasure. However, their adoptions do not necessarily prove the effectiveness and safety. Adler et al. (2025, p. 56) highlight that biometric methods including iris recognition should be handled in a transparent and strong privacy-preserving method. Thus, companies using the Orb's verification should evaluate the system while ensuring that users' biometric information is protected safely.

Sam Altman, the co-founder of Tools for Humanity, said, "I'm not afraid for the future" if people can identify humans from AI (Hays, 2026, para. 11). More sophisticated and advanced AI makes human verification necessary, and several companies around the world have started implementing it. Although AI-based iris recognition systems raise ethical problems, they can also be improved to mitigate issues and to maximize the benefits. Governments should reform the policies to be more explicit, and the providers, including Tools for Humanity, should be aware of their ethical responsibilities while improving technology in a digital world.

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